

A Reflective Journey:

Navigating Your Cumulative Experience at Iowa State University

Just over three years ago, I left my hometown to come attend Iowa State University. I was nervous and excited at the same time, as I had no idea what to expect. I attended a moderately-sized high school, so one of the things I looked forward to the most was gaining access to the resources of a large university and getting to meet new people with different backgrounds. I had heard that college was a great place to connect with people and specifically that Iowa State had a very welcoming campus. So, I was excited to experience it for myself.

The structure of Iowa State's curriculum enhanced the sense of strong community on campus that I had previously only heard about. Almost every class I took involved some sort of collaboration. Whether it was group projects, presentations, discussion boards, or lab groups, I always felt like there was an opportunity to work with new people. Although working with others presented many challenges throughout my time at Iowa State University, it helped prepare me for the real world and left me with amazing friendships and colleagues that I know I can turn to whenever I need their assistance.

In addition to a strong community, ISU has also provided me with a plethora of resources to assist me in my studies and post-grad aspirations. One of the resources I took advantage of was the Honors Mentor Program. Through this program, I was able to participate in undergraduate research with Dr. Joshua Peschel to learn more about the capabilities of generative AI. As the world becomes increasingly dependent on AI, I will have a competitive advantage over my peers because of the knowledge I gained through our research. Another resource I have really enjoyed on campus has been the career fairs. Although they haven't directly led to an internship or job for me, they have given me the opportunity to connect with industry professionals and prepare me for future interviews.

Generally, I have succeeded in my educational endeavors at Iowa State University. I have been able to achieve a 3.85 Cumulative GPA. It took lots of time, work, and effort to be able to maintain a strong GPA while navigating a challenging course load. I definitely experienced some struggles along the way. One of the things that I struggled with was my Electrical Engineering classes. I found the labs to be challenging and did not particularly enjoy solving circuit problems. These classes helped me realize that I did not want to focus on hardware design. Not only did the Electrical Engineering classes teach me about what I didn't want to do professionally, but they helped me gain perspective on the devices that my programs run on and/or control. The basic Electrical Engineering knowledge I gained will help me be less confused when colleagues need to explain a schematic to me. I also

believe that the experience of struggling through a class will be immensely beneficial for me once I begin my career. I know that I will face adversity at some point in my career, but I will be able to use the skills I learned to help me overcome challenges that I face. Afterall, I was still able to pass my Electrical Engineering courses with a decent grade.

I do think that If I were to start my college experience all over again, I would most likely choose to be a Software Engineering Major instead of a Computer Engineering Major. I remember during my sophomore year I was pondering making the switch. The reason I wanted to switch majors was because of the internship that I had since my Senior year of high school. At my internship, I started working on full stack web development. I found that I really enjoyed web development and wanted to pursue it as a career. I knew that Computer Engineering would focus more on embedded programming and that Computer Science or Software Engineering coursework would more likely line up with my interest. Additionally, if I switched majors, I would have been able to avoid the Electrical Engineering classes that I dreaded taking. However, after some consideration I decided to stick it out as a Computer Engineer. I knew that I would have some flexibility in the electives that I took and that I could use them to focus more deeply on my passion for web development. Then, the core courses that didn't line up well with web development would give me some variety and introduce me to some other topics that would be relevant for my field or potentially pique my interest in being something I would want to pursue as a career.

So no, I do not regret my decision of staying a Computer Engineer. I believe it gave me a much more wholistic view of programming and computers in general as well as made me a more well-rounded student. However, if I had already known that I wanted to pursue web development right away, I would have chosen to be a Software Engineering major. I think if I chose this path from the beginning and knew what I wanted to do, that being an SE major would have improved my web development skills more. But hindsight is always 20/20. I stepped onto campus completely unaware of what I wanted to do and what I wanted to be. I only chose Computer Engineering because I enjoyed building and programming robots in FIRST Tech Challenge (FTC) in high school. I guess what I realize is how much I have grown in the past three years. I went from being completely unsure about what career path I wanted to choose. Now, I have a job lined up for me in a career that I know I will enjoy and succeed in.

I owe Iowa State University a lot of credit for helping me grow over these past three years. I have been challenged in my coursework and have come out on the other side a much stronger and more knowledgeable person. I have also learned how to work with others, something that I know I will need to do no matter what direction I go with my career. ISU has helped me find myself as a person, and for that I am eternally grateful.